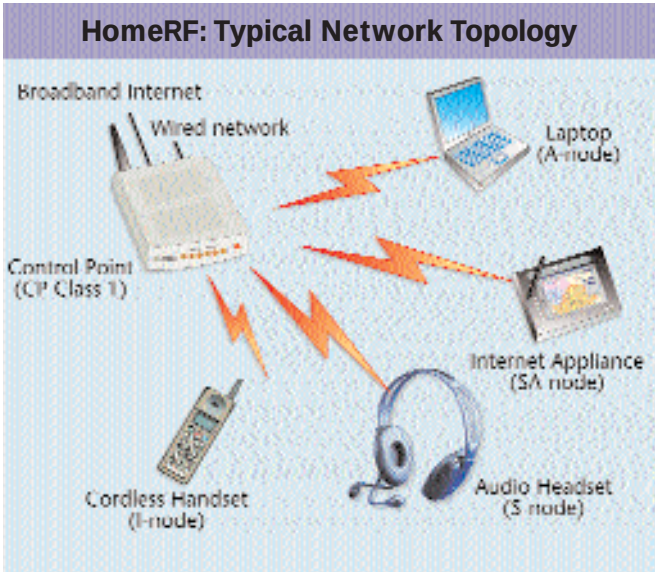




appropriate software, you could use this to voice-command your PC to wirelessly control your home environment, or simply call 'Grandma'.

HomeRF too works in the 2.4 GHz frequency range, and operates in point-to-point mode (Ad Hoc) where devices within range can simply access each other over either TCP/IP or DECT interfaces.

otherwise, traffic generated while surfing the Net would have the same priority as the voice call and would interrupt the conversation. In HomeRF the network detects the type of traffic and ensures that important data is delivered in real-time disregarding what happens with other data. HomeRF kits are a little cheaper than 802.11b, and with their additional

The key differentiator with HomeRF is QoS (Quality of Service) support for prioritised traffic. Regular networks are 'dumb' in that they make no assumptions about the data they carry. They simply forward it as it comes through. When you have streaming audio, or a phone conversation occurring, any delays in data transmission would be immediately noticeable. On a regular network, wireless or

features it may be the network you want to use at home.

The big picture

All three technologies are tested and available today. And yes, the potential is as exciting as you can imagine, maybe more. Yet, beyond niche applications we may not see them in India for a while. Bluetooth has been three years in coming and 802.11 is only just picking up momentum. That too may be slowed down till early next year because of the standards. But most importantly, there needs to be a killer application for wireless before we can see it deployed widely.

As things stand right now, businesses might adopt wireless networking only for the convenience factor, a luxury for their small mobile employee base. However, wireless equipment costs are already approaching ethernet equipment prices of only a couple of years ago. With increasing volumes, lower prices combined with the ease of deployment mean that in the long term, wireless will eventually dominate its cable dependant competitors in all but the highest performance networks. ■

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